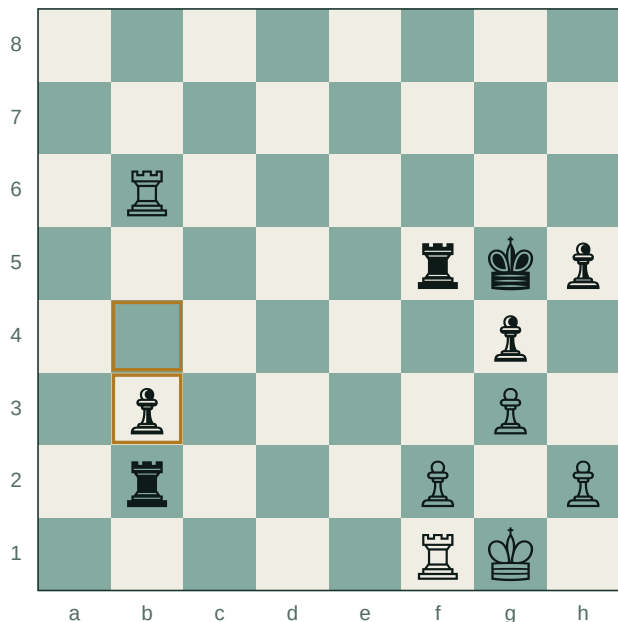


Rook-ending tactics: White, move 39

Rook-ending tactics

White to move



Previous move: 38...b3. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

39. h4+ gxh3 40. f4+

39.h4+ Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. Recorded reply: **39...gxh3**.

40.f4+ Check restricts Black to 2 legal replies here.

At the end, nominal material is White 12 / Black 13 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by -1. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** -1: the balance goes from +0 to -1. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A routine rook placement can miss a skewer or promotion with check. Let concrete tactics override a guideline when they conflict.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Rook endings combine pawn races with checks, cutoffs, and promotion tactics. Activity is vital, but the exact move order often decides whether a pawn can advance safely.

HOW TO LOOK

Check the kings' exposure, the rooks' checking distance, and the passed pawns. Calculate forcing checks before applying a general rook-ending rule.

The defending king is on g5. Geometrically undefended: rook on b2. Check for tactical protection.